

THE HARD ISSUES SERIES

Book Seven

WHAT DEACONS ACTUALLY DO

Recovering the Biblical Vision of the Church's Servant Leaders

Pastors Connection Network

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Introduction: The Most Misunderstood Office in the Church

Ask ten deacons what their job is and you will likely get ten different answers.

Some will tell you they run the church — that they are the governing board, the employer of the pastor, the decision-making authority in all matters of institutional consequence. Some will tell you they manage the physical plant — they are responsible for the building, the budget, and the maintenance requests. Some will tell you they serve communion once a month and show up for the annual business meeting. And a few — usually in churches that have done the theological work — will tell you something closer to what the New Testament actually describes: that they are servant leaders, called to meet practical needs within the congregation so that the pastors can devote themselves to prayer and the ministry of the Word.

The distance between those last two descriptions represents one of the most consequential theological and practical failures in American evangelical church life. The deacon office, as it is practiced in most churches, bears almost no resemblance to the deacon office as God designed it. And the consequences of that gap are enormous — for the congregation that needs the practical care the diaconate was designed to provide, for the pastor whose leadership is constrained by a governing board that was never meant to govern, and for the deacons themselves, who deserve to understand the significance and the specific character

of the calling they have accepted.

This book is a recovery project. It takes the relevant biblical texts seriously, examines the history that produced the current dysfunction, and offers a clear and practical picture of what a genuinely biblical diaconate looks like in a real local church. The goal is not to diminish the significance of deacon ministry. It is to elevate it — to show that what deacons are called to do is not lesser than what elders do, but different from it, and that the difference is essential to the church's health.

And the twelve summoned the full number of the disciples and said, 'It is not right that we should give up preaching the word of God to serve tables.' — Acts 6:2

The phrase "serve tables" in Acts 6:2 is the origin of the diaconal office. And it is worth noting what the apostles are saying here. They are not saying that serving tables is unimportant. They are saying that the specific calling of the apostles — to devote themselves to prayer and the ministry of the Word — is incompatible with also meeting every practical need personally. The solution is not to neglect the practical need. It is to appoint people specifically equipped and specifically commissioned for that work. That is the deacon.

CHAPTER ONE

The Problem: Deacons Who Govern Instead of Serve

How the most important thing about the diaconate got lost

The deacon board that functions as a church's governing authority is not a New Testament institution. It is an American one.

The pathway from Acts 6 to the modern governance board is not a direct line of theological development. It is a history of cultural accommodation, institutional pragmatism, and the gradual displacement of a biblical office by a business model. Understanding how we got here is the first step toward getting somewhere better.

The Historical Displacement

In the earliest centuries of the church, the diaconal office was understood as a specific ministry of mercy and practical service. Deacons administered the distribution of food and resources to the poor, cared for widows and orphans, managed the practical logistics of the gathered community, and extended the pastoral reach of the bishop or elder by meeting needs that the preaching ministry could not personally address. The office was honored precisely because of its servant character — the deacon was not a lesser leader but a different one, serving the body in ways that freed the preaching ministry to do what only it could do.

The displacement began as churches grew larger and more institutionally complex, and as the American cultural model of organizational governance was applied to the church. In many Baptist and free-church traditions, the absence of a developed elder structure created a governance vacuum that the deacon board filled by default. The deacon was the only formal lay leadership office available, and so it absorbed the governance functions that the culture expected lay leadership to perform. Over generations, this became the tradition. The deacon board became the governing board. And the servant character of the office was gradually forgotten.

What the Current Model Costs

The cost of the governance-deacon model is specific and serious, and it is distributed across every member of the church.

The pastor bears the cost of constrained leadership. When a board of deacons functions as the pastor's employer — approving his decisions, limiting his authority, and exercising veto power over his ministry initiatives — the pastor's ability to lead is perpetually qualified. He cannot move quickly because every significant step requires board approval. He cannot build the kind of team he needs because the board controls staffing. And he cannot give the congregation the confident pastoral leadership that genuine trust in God's call requires, because his authority is always provisional, always subject to the board's next vote.

The congregation bears the cost of unmet practical needs. The diaconate was designed to meet the congregation's practical needs — to care for widows, to distribute resources to those in want, to ensure that no member slipped through the cracks of the community's practical care. When the diaconate is occupied with governance functions, those practical needs are left unaddressed. The

congregation that has a twelve-member deacon board that meets monthly to review the budget has twelve people in institutional meetings who might otherwise be visiting the elderly, supporting struggling families, and building the practical infrastructure of a caring community.

The deacons themselves bear the cost of a diminished calling. Most deacons who function primarily as governors were not called to governance. They were called to serve. And the man who accepted the diaconate because he wanted to care for people, to meet practical needs, to extend the love of Christ in tangible ways — and who finds himself spending his deacon time on policy discussions and budget reviews — is a man whose genuine calling has been redirected into a role that does not fit it. The frustration this produces is real, even when it is rarely named.

The Theological Foundation for Change

Recovering a biblical diaconate does not require tearing down what exists. It requires helping the people who hold the office understand what they were actually called to do — and finding that the calling is more compelling, more meaningful, and more genuinely significant than the governance role they have been inhabiting.

This is the pastoral opportunity that the history of displacement has created. The deacons in your church are not the enemy of the biblical vision. They are the potential beneficiaries of it. Most of them became deacons because they wanted to serve. Most of them will respond positively to a pastor who helps them see that what the New Testament describes for the diaconate is exactly what they hoped the role would be when they accepted it.

The recovery of the biblical diaconate begins not with a governance restructuring but with a theological conversation — an honest, patient, Scripture-rooted engagement with what the office actually is and what it is not. That is where this book begins.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What function does your church's diaconate currently perform? Is it primarily governance, primarily service, or some combination?

What would your current deacons say if you asked them why they became deacons? What drew them to the office, and what are they actually doing in it?

What practical needs in your congregation are currently unmet because the diaconate is occupied with institutional functions? Can you name specific people or situations?

How much of the pastor's leadership is currently constrained by the governance role your deacon board performs? What decisions require board approval that the pastor should be authorized to make?

CHAPTER TWO

The Origin of the Diaconate: Acts 6

What the first deacons were actually called to do

Every understanding of the diaconate must begin in Acts 6, because Acts 6 is where the diaconal office originates. Not as a theoretical construct developed in a later epistle, but as the practical solution to a specific problem in a specific community. Understanding that problem, and the specific solution the apostles proposed, is the foundation of everything that follows.

The Problem That Created the Office

The problem was specific and practical: the Hellenist widows were being neglected in the daily distribution. This is a statement of institutional failure. The early Jerusalem church had developed a practice of caring for its vulnerable members — particularly widows, who had no male family member providing for them and who depended on the community's active support. But as the church grew, and as the demographic diversity of the community increased, the system had broken down. The Hellenist widows — Greek-speaking Jewish Christians whose cultural background was distinct from the native Hebrew-speaking majority — were not receiving the same care as the others.

This was not a minor administrative inconvenience. It was a failure of Christian love, a breakdown in the practical expression of the community's commitment to one another, and a potential source of the exactly the kind of factional division that the New Testament consistently warns against. The apostles took it seriously.

The Apostles' Response

The apostles' response in Acts 6:2–4 is one of the most theologically rich and practically instructive passages in the New Testament for understanding church leadership. “It is not right that we should give up preaching the word of God to serve tables. Therefore, brothers, pick out from among you seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom, whom we will appoint to this duty. But we will devote ourselves to prayer and to the ministry of the word.”

Several things about this response deserve careful attention.

First, the apostles did not say that serving tables was unimportant. They said it was incompatible with their specific calling — to prayer and the ministry of the Word. The distinction is critical. The apostles were not diminishing the practical work of caring for widows. They were acknowledging that their specific calling required a focused devotion that excluded doing everything personally. The church needed both: the ministry of the Word and the ministry of tables. The solution was not to neglect one for the other but to appoint specific people for each.

Second, the qualifications given for the seven are striking in their spiritual seriousness. The text does not say “Pick seven men who are good at administration.” It says men “of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom.” The practical work of caring for widows was to be done by people of genuine spiritual character — people whose lives reflected the Holy Spirit's formation, whose wisdom was genuine rather than merely pragmatic. Service was not a lower-tier calling that could be filled by spiritually mediocre people. It was a holy calling that required holy people.

Pick out from among you seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom, whom we will appoint to this duty. But we will devote ourselves to prayer and to the ministry of the word. — Acts 6:3–4

Third, the result of the appointment was remarkable: “And the word of God continued to increase, and the number of the disciples multiplied greatly in Jerusalem, and a great many of the priests became obedient to the faith.” When the practical care of the community was properly structured, the ministry of the Word flourished. This is not coincidental. The liberation of the apostles for their specific calling, combined with the liberation of the deacons for theirs, produced multiplicative rather than merely additive ministry impact.

What the First Deacons Were Doing

The seven appointed in Acts 6 were managing the daily distribution. In practical terms, this means they were overseeing the process by which the community's resources were gathered, accounted for, and distributed to those who needed them. They were ensuring that no one was overlooked — that the demographic and cultural biases that had produced the initial failure were addressed, and that every widow in the community received care regardless of her background.

This is not governance work. It is mercy work. It is the practical, hands-on, logistically demanding, relationally intensive work of caring for vulnerable people within the community. The deacons were not setting policy. They were meeting needs. And the theological dignity of that work — caring for widows in the name of the God who is himself described as a father to the fatherless and a defender of widows (Psalm 68:5) — was not lesser than the theological dignity of the apostles' preaching and prayer. It was different. And the difference was essential to the whole.

From Acts 6 to Today

The principle that emerges from Acts 6 is enduring and applicable across every cultural context: the church needs both the ministry of the Word and the ministry of practical service, and those two ministries are best served by people specifically called and specifically commissioned for each.

Applied to the contemporary church, this means that deacons are the people who ensure that the congregation's practical needs are being met — that no one slips through the cracks, that the vulnerable are known and cared for, that the physical infrastructure of the community's life together is maintained, and that the pastors are freed to devote themselves to what only they can do. This is a high and holy calling. It is not lesser than pastoral ministry. It is its essential complement.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What specific practical needs in your congregation are analogous to the neglect of the Hellenist widows — needs that are going unmet because the diaconate is occupied elsewhere?

The apostles described their specific calling as 'prayer and the ministry of the word.' How much of your pastoral capacity is currently consumed by practical

functions that could and should be handled by deacons?

What would it mean for your diaconate to be filled with people who are ‘full of the Spirit and of wisdom’? Is that the standard your current selection process produces?

What would change in your church’s ministry fruitfulness if the pastoral staff was genuinely freed for prayer and the Word, and the diaconate was genuinely meeting the community’s practical needs?

CHAPTER THREE

The Distinction Between Elder and Deacon

Authority and oversight versus service and mercy

One of the most important — and most practically consequential — distinctions in New Testament ecclesiology is the distinction between the elder and the deacon. These are not the same office. They are not interchangeable titles. They describe different callings, different functions, and different forms of authority in the life of the local church.

This distinction is frequently obscured in practice. Many churches have either collapsed the two offices into one — treating all formal leaders as a single governing body regardless of their designation — or have assigned governance functions to the diaconate that the elder office was designed to perform. The result, in either case, is a church whose leadership structure does not function as God designed it and whose members receive neither the oversight nor the service they need.

What Distinguishes the Two Offices

The elder (presbuteros, episkopos, poimen) is charged with oversight, teaching, and the protection of the flock. His authority is genuine and his accountability is high — Hebrews 13:17 describes him as one who “keeps watch over your souls.” He exercises authority by teaching sound doctrine, protecting the congregation from false teaching, providing spiritual direction, and modeling the Christian life in

ways the congregation can observe and follow. His is the authority of wisdom, character, and spiritual formation communicated through relationship and truth.

The deacon (diakonos) is charged with service and mercy. His authority — if we can call it that — is the authority of faithful, Spirit-filled service. He is not called to oversee souls. He is called to meet practical needs so thoroughly and so faithfully that no one in the community lacks what the community can provide. The deacon's work is concrete, relational, and often invisible — the kind of work that does not appear in the pulpit or in the meeting minutes but that makes the community's life together genuinely possible.

The Overlapping Qualifications and the One Significant Difference

When Paul lists the qualifications for deacons in 1 Timothy 3:8–13, the overlap with the elder qualifications is significant. Deacons must be dignified, not double-tongued, not addicted to much wine, not greedy for dishonest gain. They must hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. They must be the husband of one wife and manage their children and households well. The character standard is not lower for the deacon than for the elder. Both offices require genuine spiritual formation and genuine moral integrity.

The one qualification that appears in the elder list but not the deacon list is “able to teach” (1 Timothy 3:2). The elder must be able to give instruction in sound doctrine and rebuke those who contradict it. The deacon is not required to be a teacher in this sense. This is not because doctrine is unimportant to the deacon — Paul specifies that deacons must “hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience,” meaning they must possess sound doctrine personally even if they are not charged with teaching it publicly. The distinction is between the one who guards and proclaims doctrine and the one who must simply hold it faithfully.

This is the functional difference between the two offices in distilled form: the elder teaches and oversees, the deacon serves and meets needs. Both require genuine character. Both carry genuine significance. But they are oriented toward different dimensions of the congregation's life.

What This Means Practically

The practical implications of this distinction are direct and significant. If the elder is charged with oversight and teaching, then decisions about doctrinal direction,

pastoral care, and the church's spiritual formation belong to the elder team. The deacon board does not vote on sermon series, doctrinal positions, or pastoral strategies. Those belong to the elders.

If the deacon is charged with service and mercy, then decisions about how the congregation's practical needs are being met belong to the diaconate. Who is receiving care from the benevolence fund? How is the building being stewarded? What practical support is being provided to families in crisis? These belong to the deacons.

Institutional decisions — major financial commitments, property matters, significant structural changes — belong to the congregation as a whole, affirmed through appropriate governance processes. The elder team may make recommendations. The deacon team may implement decisions. But the congregation holds the ultimate institutional authority.

This division of responsibility is clean in theory. In practice, it requires ongoing conversation and calibration. But the church that has genuinely embraced it will find that its pastoral ministry is more focused, its practical care is more comprehensive, and its governance decisions are less contentious, because each party is operating within a well-defined sphere of responsibility rather than competing for authority across undefined boundaries.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

How clearly does your church currently distinguish between the elder's oversight/teaching function and the deacon's service/mercy function? Is that distinction reflected in how meetings are run and decisions are made?

What decisions are currently being made by your deacon board that should belong to the pastoral leadership? What decisions belong to the congregation but are currently being made by the board?

How do you communicate the distinction between elder and deacon qualifications to your congregation? Does the congregation understand why both offices require genuine spiritual character?

What would it look like for your diaconate to have a genuinely distinct portfolio of practical ministry responsibility — things they own and lead rather than simply approve or oversee?

CHAPTER FOUR

What Deacons Can Own and Lead

A practical ministry portfolio for the biblical diaconate

The question that most naturally follows a recovery of the biblical diaconate's identity is a practical one: if deacons are not governors, what are they? What do they actually do? What specific ministries belong to them, what responsibilities do they carry, and how does their work connect to the congregation's broader life?

These are the right questions, and they deserve specific and honest answers. The deacon office is not a blank canvas onto which any ministry can be projected. It has a specific character — service, mercy, and the meeting of practical needs — and the ministries that belong to it share that character. What follows is a description of the primary categories of deacon ministry, with enough practical specificity to provide a working model for a congregation that is rebuilding its diaconate around biblical foundations.

Mercy Ministry and Benevolence

The original diaconal function was the care of vulnerable people within the community — the widows of Acts 6. In the contemporary church, this ministry of mercy encompasses a broader range of practical care, but it retains the same essential character: ensuring that no member of the community lacks what the community can provide.

Deacons who own the mercy ministry are responsible for knowing the congregation's practical needs. They maintain awareness of families in financial crisis, of elderly members who need practical support, of young families facing overwhelming transitions, of members whose circumstances have placed them in genuine vulnerability. They are not waiting for people to ask for help — they are proactively looking for need and responding to it with the resources the community provides.

This ministry requires the development of a benevolence system that is both structured enough to be accountable and flexible enough to respond to genuine need with appropriate speed and discretion. Deacons who lead this ministry

design the system, steward its resources, and make individual decisions about assistance with wisdom, consistency, and genuine pastoral compassion. They are not implementing a policy. They are expressing the love of Christ in practical form.

The benevolence ministry also extends beyond the congregation's membership to the surrounding community. The church that cares for its own and also serves its neighbors through practical mercy ministry is demonstrating the gospel in ways that its preaching can only point toward. Deacons who lead this expanded mercy ministry are among the most effective evangelists the church possesses — not because they are proclaiming the Word directly, but because they are living it visibly.

Care for the Elderly and Homebound

One of the most consistent gaps in congregational care is the care of elderly, homebound, and isolated members. These are the members who cannot easily get to the building, who are not visible in the normal rhythms of church life, and who are therefore most at risk of being overlooked as the congregation's attention focuses on the activities and events that attract visible participation.

Deacons who own the care of elderly and homebound members take specific responsibility for maintaining regular contact with people in these circumstances. Not a perfunctory quarterly check-in, but genuine, regular, relational investment in people who are often lonely and who are deeply grateful for a community that remembers them. This care includes visits, phone calls, practical help with transportation or errands, and the kind of pastoral presence that communicates: you are not forgotten, you are valued, and the community that calls itself the body of Christ actually intends to function as one.

This dimension of deacon ministry is not glamorous. It does not generate the social energy of a church event or the institutional visibility of a board decision. But it is among the most faithful expressions of the diaconal calling, and the congregation that has deacons genuinely invested in it is a congregation that is caring for its members with a comprehensiveness that reflects the character of the God they serve.

Facilities, Hospitality, and the Physical Infrastructure of Community

The physical environment in which a congregation worships, gathers, and meets matters. Not because buildings are more important than people, but because the physical environment either supports or impedes the community's life together. The sanctuary that is clean and well-maintained communicates care and intentionality. The hospitality that makes guests feel genuinely welcomed communicates the community's posture toward the outsider. The logistics of events and gatherings that are managed well free the congregation's attention for relationship and worship rather than consuming it with confusion and discomfort.

Deacons who own this dimension of ministry are stewarding the physical infrastructure of the community's life together. They are not merely managing a building. They are curating the environment in which the congregation encounters each other, encounters guests, and together encounters God. That is a ministry with genuine theological significance.

The hospitality dimension of this ministry deserves particular emphasis. The deacon who ensures that every guest is genuinely welcomed — not just acknowledged, but personally engaged, followed up with, and connected to the community — is doing evangelistic work in the most concrete possible form. The church that has mastered practical hospitality is the church that retains the guests its preaching attracts.

Event and Logistics Ministry

The practical management of the church's community life — Sunday morning setup and tear-down, shared meals and celebrations, special services and community events — falls naturally within the diaconate's portfolio. These are not spiritual activities in the sense that preaching is spiritual. But they are the logistics that make community possible. The meal that connects people across generations, the event that creates the context for a meaningful conversation, the community gathering that gives belonging a concrete expression — all of these require the practical investment that the diaconate is specifically designed to provide.

The deacon who leads a church's event and community life ministry is not a hospitality coordinator. He is a minister of the practical grace that makes community real rather than merely aspirational. And the community that experiences his ministry well will not typically attribute its warmth to the deacon's logistical competence. They will simply feel genuinely at home, genuinely known,

and genuinely loved. That is the invisible ministry of the diaconate at its best.

Financial Stewardship: The Deacon as Servant, Not Governor

Many churches assign financial oversight to their deacon board, and there is a legitimate basis for this in the diaconate's original function of distributing resources to those in need. However, the nature of the deacon's financial role requires clarification, because it is frequently confused with a governance function that it is not.

The deacon's appropriate financial role is stewardship of designated service funds and oversight of the practical use of resources assigned to mercy and community ministry. It is not the governance of the church's overall budget, the approval of the pastoral staff's compensation, or the exercise of financial authority over the senior pastor's ministry. Those functions belong either to the elder team or to the congregation, depending on the church's polity.

The deacon who manages the benevolence fund, who tracks the use of practical ministry resources, and who ensures that the community's financial generosity is being translated into practical care with integrity and accountability — this deacon is performing a genuine and important financial ministry. The deacon who uses the financial oversight role to control the pastor's compensation, to limit the church's ministry budget according to his personal preferences, or to exercise institutional power over the direction of the church — this deacon has moved outside the boundaries of the office.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What specific ministry areas could your current deacons own and lead with full responsibility? Are those areas clearly defined and genuinely transferred to their ownership?

Who in your congregation is most likely to be overlooked — elderly, homebound, financially struggling, socially isolated? Are deacons specifically responsible for knowing those people and caring for them?

How does the physical environment and hospitality culture of your church reflect the quality of your diaconate's ministry? What would improvement in those areas look like?

Where is the deacon's financial role currently exceeding its appropriate scope in your context? What would it look like to redefine that scope in a way that serves both the deacons and the pastor?

CHAPTER FIVE

Women as Deacons

Navigating the exegetical question with pastoral wisdom

Few questions in the diaconate conversation generate more heat and less light than the question of whether women can serve as deacons. The heat is understandable — the question touches on deeply held convictions about Scripture, gender, and the nature of church office. The lack of light is unnecessary — the exegetical evidence is specific enough, and the pastoral implications are clear enough, that a thoughtful and honest engagement with the question is possible even where full agreement is not.

This chapter does not argue for a specific conclusion about women in the diaconate. It surveys the relevant biblical evidence honestly, describes the positions the evidence supports, and offers pastoral wisdom for navigating the question in a specific congregation regardless of which position is held.

The Exegetical Evidence

The two primary texts that bear directly on this question are Romans 16:1 and 1 Timothy 3:11.

Romans 16:1 introduces Phoebe as a “servant of the church at Cenchreae.” The Greek word translated “servant” is *diakonos* — the same word used for the male deacons Paul describes in Philippians 1:1 and 1 Timothy 3:8–13. Paul commends Phoebe and asks the Roman church to “help her in whatever she may need from you, for she has been a patron of many and of myself as well.” The question is whether Paul is describing a formal office (*diakonos* = deacon) or a functional description of service (*diakonos* = servant). Scholars who understand Paul to be describing a formal office note that he uses the same word to describe Tychicus (Ephesians 6:21), who is widely understood to hold a recognized ministry role.

First Timothy 3:11 occurs in the middle of Paul's discussion of deacon qualifications. "Women likewise must be dignified, not slanderers, but sober-minded, faithful in all things." The interpretive question is whether "women" here refers to deacons' wives (giving requirements for a specific relationship of women to the diaconate) or to women who are themselves deacons (giving requirements for a specific category of deacon). The Greek word is simply *gunaikes*, which can mean either "women" or "wives." Both readings are grammatically possible. Context and theological framework determine which reading one adopts.

Those who understand 3:11 to refer to women deacons note that (1) no article or possessive pronoun connects *gunaikes* to the deacons described in the preceding verses, making "their wives" a somewhat forced reading; (2) the structure "likewise" parallels the introduction of the deacon qualifications in 3:8, suggesting a third category of qualified servants rather than a subset of the second; and (3) Paul does not include a similar requirement for elders' wives when listing elder qualifications, making the insertion of a wives requirement specifically in the deacon section structurally awkward.

Those who understand 3:11 to refer to deacons' wives note that (1) the absence of full parallel qualification lists — no "husband of one wife" requirement is given for women — suggests that women are not being described as deacons in the full sense; (2) the immediately following verses (3:12–13) return to male pronouns and "husband of one wife" language; and (3) the church's historic majority interpretation has generally understood this verse as referring to wives.

Three Pastoral Positions and Their Implications

Churches navigate this question in three primary ways, each of which has legitimate biblical support and genuine pastoral implications.

Position 1: Women may serve as deacons in the full formal sense of the office. Churches holding this position typically understand Romans 16:1 as describing a formally recognized female deacon and 1 Timothy 3:11 as providing qualifications for women who hold the office alongside men. The pastoral implication is the formal appointment of qualified women to the diaconate with the same standing, responsibilities, and recognition as male deacons.

Position 2: Women may not hold the formal office of deacon, but their service in diaconal functions should be recognized and honored. Churches holding this

position typically understand the “husband of one wife” qualification as limiting formal deacon installation to men, while recognizing that the mercy ministry, hospitality, and practical care functions of the diaconate are performed by women throughout the congregation and deserve clear recognition. The pastoral implication is the development of recognized service roles for women that honor their contribution to diaconal ministry without formal installation as deacons.

Position 3: The office itself should be understood as gender-neutral, and the question should be decided contextually rather than universally. Churches holding this position typically hold the exegetical evidence to be genuinely ambiguous and make contextual decisions about how to handle it based on their denomination’s guidance, their congregation’s culture, and their assessment of what best serves the community’s ministry.

Pastoral Wisdom for Your Context

The most important pastoral practice regardless of which position your church holds is the honest recognition and genuine honor of the women who are doing the work of the diaconate — formally or informally, titled or untitled. The congregation whose women are visibly and specifically honored for their servant ministry is a congregation that is being formed in a healthy theology of the diaconate. The congregation that treats the women’s service as background noise while giving the formal recognition only to the men is a congregation that has reduced the diaconate to an institutional title rather than a genuine calling.

This also means ensuring that qualified women have genuine ownership of significant ministry areas rather than peripheral involvement in the margins of ministries men are leading. The deacon who leads the benevolence ministry with full ownership, who designs and manages the care systems, who makes decisions with genuine authority in her area of responsibility — this woman is functioning as a deacon in every meaningful sense of the term. Whether she carries the formal title depends on your theological position. Whether her calling is honored depends on your pastoral wisdom.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What is your church’s current theological position on women as deacons? Is that position the product of genuine exegetical engagement, or has it simply been

inherited without examination?

How does your congregation currently honor the women who are doing the practical work of mercy ministry, hospitality, and congregational care? Is that honor adequate?

Are there qualified women in your congregation who have gifts and calling for diaconal ministry who are currently not given appropriate ownership of significant ministry areas? What would change if they were?

How would you navigate a congregational disagreement about this question if it arose? Do you have a framework for the conversation, or would it catch you unprepared?

CHAPTER SIX

Rebuilding a Biblical Diaconate

Starting from where you are and moving toward where you should be

The recovery of a biblical diaconate in a church that has had a governance-focused diaconate for decades is not a quick process. It is a patient, pastoral, primarily educational investment that unfolds over years rather than months. And it is worth every year it takes.

The approach that works is not the approach that begins with structural reform. Churches that attempt to change the governance function of the diaconate by revising the bylaws and redesigning the meeting agenda before changing the theological understanding of the people involved will almost always produce conflict rather than transformation. The deacons who have been governing for thirty years will not respond well to being told that their role has been wrong. They will respond — sometimes very well — to being invited into a richer understanding of what they were actually called to do.

Begin With Education, Not Restructuring

The first and most important step in recovering a biblical diaconate is helping your current deacons understand what the office actually is. This is best done through

patient, relational, Scripture-focused teaching — not a formal lecture about ecclesiastical polity, but an ongoing conversation rooted in specific biblical texts and genuine curiosity about what those texts mean for your specific community.

A deacon study — a series of meetings or a structured discussion over several months — that walks the deacon team through Acts 6, 1 Timothy 3, and the other relevant texts, asking honest questions rather than delivering predetermined conclusions, is among the most effective tools available for this work. The questions to ask are not “Should deacons govern or serve?” — that framing puts people on the defensive. The questions to ask are: “What do we observe in the text about what the first deacons were doing? What does Paul seem to understand the deacon’s role to be? How does what we’re currently doing compare to what we’re reading? What would we want to change?”

This approach invites the deacons into a process of discovery rather than presenting them with a conclusion they are expected to accept. And it respects their genuine love for the church — a love that, in most cases, originally motivated their acceptance of the office. People who love their church will usually be willing to consider how they can serve it more effectively when the question is framed in terms of serving rather than in terms of relinquishing power.

The Incremental Meeting Agenda Shift

Once the theological conversation is underway, the most practical way to begin moving the diaconate toward a more biblical function is through gradual changes to the meeting agenda. The same principle that applies to the elder meeting applies here: what the meeting spends time on communicates what the team values and what the role is for.

A deacon meeting that spends its first thirty minutes on budget review and facilities reports before turning briefly to any discussion of congregational needs is a meeting whose agenda communicates that institutional management is the primary function. A deacon meeting that begins with a specific discussion of practical needs in the congregation — who is struggling financially, who needs a meal train, who just came home from the hospital, who has a need the benevolence fund should address — before moving to institutional business is a meeting whose agenda communicates something very different.

The transition does not need to be dramatic. Adding a standing agenda item at the

beginning of every deacon meeting — “Need reports: who in the congregation has a practical need we should be addressing?” — is a small change that begins to reshape the meeting’s identity. Over months and years, as the deacons experience the genuine satisfaction of meeting real needs and as the pastoral ministry of the congregation improves as a result, the agenda will gradually reorient itself around the ministry function rather than the governance function.

Assigning Specific Ministry Ownership

A key structural change in moving from a governance diaconate to a service diaconate is the assignment of specific ministry ownership to individual deacons or small groups of deacons. Rather than having the full deacon board make collective decisions about everything, each deacon is given genuine ownership of a specific area of ministry — the benevolence fund, the care of elderly members, the hospitality and guest welcome ministry, the practical support for families in crisis. They are not reporting to the board on these areas. They are leading them, with the board’s knowledge and support but not its approval for every decision.

This change shifts the deacon from institutional participant to active minister. It gives the role a concrete and specific expression that connects to the genuine calling the deacon felt when they accepted the office. And it produces visible ministry results — needs being met, people being cared for, the community’s practical life being improved — that reinforce the value of the new model more effectively than any theological argument.

When the Governance Role Must Be Reassigned

Some of the governance functions currently performed by the deacon board will need to find a new home as the diaconate is recovered. Major financial decisions, personnel matters, and significant institutional governance questions belong either to the elder team (in a church with genuine elder plurality) or to the congregation itself (in a congregational polity church). They do not belong to the diaconate.

The reassignment of these functions requires honesty about what is happening and pastoral sensitivity about the transition. The deacons who have been exercising these governance functions are not being punished. They are being relieved of responsibilities that were never theirs to carry, and freed for the

ministry they were actually called to. Framed this way — and accompanied by the genuine ministry ownership described above — the transition can be received as a gift rather than a diminishment.

This framing requires the pastor to genuinely mean it. The deacons who lose the governance role and gain nothing in its place will rightly conclude that they have simply been diminished. The deacons who lose the governance role and gain genuine, meaningful, valued ministry ownership in its place will discover that what they now do is more satisfying, more consistent with their calling, and more clearly connected to the congregation's actual health than the governance role ever was.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Where would you begin the educational conversation with your current deacons? What specific texts would you use, and what questions would you ask?

What incremental change in your monthly deacon meeting would begin to shift its culture most effectively? What is the smallest change you could make at the next meeting?

What specific ministry areas could you assign to individual deacons with genuine ownership? Would your current deacons welcome that kind of specific responsibility?

How will you frame the reassignment of governance functions to the deacons who are currently exercising them? What do you need to offer them in return that is genuinely valuable?

Conclusion: The Deacon as a Picture of the Gospel

The diaconate, properly understood and faithfully practiced, is one of the most powerful testimonies to the gospel that a local church possesses.

The gospel says that the Son of God came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many. The diaconate says, in every act of practical mercy, every care for the vulnerable, every concrete expression of the community's commitment to one another: we follow a Servant, and his character is showing in

our life together.

The world is watching the church. Not primarily to see whether its theology is correct or its governance is well-organized. The world is watching to see whether the community that claims to be transformed by the love of God actually loves its members in concrete and visible ways. The deacon who visits the elderly widow every week, who ensures that the struggling family has groceries, who makes the first-time guest feel genuinely welcome, who cares for the physical space in which the community gathers as an act of love for the people who will use it — this deacon is demonstrating the gospel in ways that no sermon alone can demonstrate it.

That is the calling. It is not a lesser calling than the elder's. It is a different one, with its own beauty, its own demands, and its own profound significance. The church that recovers this vision of the diaconate will find that its mercy ministry deepens, its community strengthens, its guests are retained, its pastor is freed, and its witness to the watching world is more compelling than any institutional improvement it could achieve.

Serve the tables. The King of the universe became a servant. Following him into that work is among the highest things any of his people can do.

For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many. — Matthew 20:28